

THE OPENING SHOT.

Six months of extraction, discovery, and the occasional revelation.

38	20	14	6	1
cups logged	cafés visited	countries of origin	months of field work	all-time favourite found

A NOTE FROM HARISH

I didn't set out to keep a record. The archive started as a few notes on my phone — a varietal name I didn't want to forget, a grinder I wanted to look up later. By March, it had become something else entirely.

Six months later, I have 38 entries across four cities, logged with the kind of obsessive detail that would probably concern anyone who isn't a specialty coffee person. For those of you who are: you already understand. The cup is never just a cup.

This letter is my attempt to make sense of the first half of 2026 — not as a spreadsheet (though there is one), but as a journey. The Bali morning that started it. The father-daughter sessions that gave it meaning. The cafés that surprised me. The ones that didn't. The cup that I keep returning to as the benchmark for everything else.

The Holy Trinity — three varietals I'd been chasing, all captured washed within a single month — deserves its own paragraph. So does the morning of 28 June, when I walked out of two different cafés before noon having ticked off two archive firsts in a single session. That kind of day doesn't happen by accident.

What follows is not comprehensive. It is, I hope, honest. These are the cups that stayed with me — the ones that rewired something, or confirmed something, or simply made a Tuesday afternoon feel like it mattered.

Harish

Singapore, June 2026

“
The cup is never just a cup.

The archive opens in Bali and closes — for now — in Singapore, on a Sunday morning when I managed two milestone cups before noon. In between: one solo February, a blur of March sessions across Mumbai and Singapore, April's benchmark discoveries, the slow burn of May, and June's sudden acceleration. Here is how it unfolded.

JAN

4

The archive opens in Bali

Ubud, Bali

A family trip. Seniman Coffee Studio, tucked into the Ubud rice-field sprawl. I ordered the Kintamani Natural almost as an afterthought — and found myself taking notes on my phone. The Sulawesi Toraja followed, all wet-hulled density and cocoa. Three cups, three entries. The archive had begun, though I didn't know it yet.

FEB

6

One cup, one signal

Singapore

A quiet month. One session, one entry — Kenya Kiamugumo AA at Kyuukei. SL28 and SL34, fully washed, phosphoric acid structure that coated the palate and stayed there. That long Kenyan aftertaste is a genetic signature, not a roast artifact. February felt like a single, clear note played in an otherwise empty room.

MAR

28

The busiest month — and the most personal

Mumbai + Singapore

Thirteen cups across two cities in one month. Mumbai opened with Subko's Project Pearl and Grey Soul's Zoya Estate — interesting, but India's anaerobic profile felt restrained compared to what I was used to. Then Singapore: a father-daughter afternoon at Narrative where Aanya ordered the Finca La Siberia Natural and announced it tasted like apricot. Her first specialty filter. I wrote it down immediately. The month ended at Asylum with a washed Peruvian Gesha, flash-chilled — elegant, pure, and the beginning of something.

APR

24

The Holy Trinity, completed

Singapore + Johor Bahru

April arrived with Maxi Coffee Bar's La Laja — a washed Sudan Rume from Cauca that hit nectarine and raspberry with surgical clarity. Then a rainy CBD afternoon at Lume, a Panamanian Geisha with structured honey sweetness. On the 5th, Asylum again: back with Aanya, two cups, the Peru Gesha completing the Holy Trinity. Wush Wush in March, Sudan Rume and Gesha in April — all washed. I hadn't planned it that way. Then a cross-border run to Johor: Hacienda La Florida's Typica Mejorado — MYR 35 (about SGD 11), lime when hot and distinct plum on the cool. The furthest I'd travelled for a cup.

MAY

27

Nylon, four ways

Singapore

Four entries across two days at Nylon Coffee Roasters. Two Brazils — FAF Organic's malic front and Serra dos Ciganos' sweet linger. Then the Ethiopia Banko Gotiti washed: lemon up front, melon in the middle, clean white tea finish. And the Nicaragua Buena Vista Natural Anaerobic — thick, savoury, nothing like the others. Nylon doesn't play it safe. That week reminded me why I keep going back.

JUN

28

The acceleration, and a morning I won't forget

Singapore

Ten entries in nineteen days. Rwanda at Kurasu. Colombia at Keryi, then a return that same week. The first Liberica in the archive — Corner Corner, vinyl records on the walls, a cup that smelled of longan and tasted like nothing else I'd catalogued. Then Sunday, June 28th: Keryi at 10:30 for the Urabeast G1 Mosto Fermentation — a process first. Walked straight to Asylum by 11:06 for the Yellow Sudan Rume EF2. Two firsts before noon. The archive has never had a day like it.

THREE CUPS THAT CHANGED SOMETHING

PERSONAL BENCHMARKS FROM H1 2026

Not every entry earns a second paragraph. These three did. Each one shifted something — a benchmark raised, a palate recalibrated, a gap in the archive finally filled.

THE ALL-TIME BENCHMARK

El Obraje

Fluid Collective · Washed Colombia Gesha · Cauca

There are cups you remember clearly, and then there is El Obraje. I visited Fluid Collective on a weekday afternoon, nothing particular planned — and walked out having recalibrated every expectation I had for what a washed Gesha could be.

The hot phase opened with malic stone fruit — not the sharp citric zip I'd come to expect from Colombian washed lots, but something softer, more integrated. White peach with precision. As it cooled, the acid didn't fade; it transformed. Citric and malic running in parallel, neither overwhelming the other. The finish was long, clean, and left the palate genuinely still.

Every Gesha I've had since has been measured against this cup. That's what a benchmark actually means — not a high score, but a reference point you can't stop returning to. I've sent Fluid Collective a DM about their current rotation. I'm already planning the next visit.

THE VARIETAL REVELATION

La Laja (James Fernandez)

Maxi Coffee Bar · Washed Sudan Rume · Cauca, Colombia

Sudan Rume was on my list. I'd read about the genetics — a wild Ethiopian variety, rare, demanding, the kind of bean that most farms won't bother with because the yields are too low. But reading about a varietal and actually drinking it are very different things.

La Laja arrived at Maxi Coffee Bar on a CBD lunch break — a washed lot from James Fernandez in Cauca, served with the kind of quiet confidence that good baristas have when they know what's in the cup. The first sip was nectarine. Clear, immediate, not fruity-adjacent but *actually nectarine*. Then raspberry — a brighter note underneath. The dual-acid structure was textbook: citric brightness on top, malic smoothness on the finish.

It was the first washed Sudan Rume in the archive, and it sat the Holy Trinity in motion. A cup that didn't just taste good — it explained something.

THE PROCESS MILESTONE

Yellow Sudan Rume EF2

Asylum Coffeehouse · Extended Fermentation Natural · Pijiao, Quindío

The Yellow Sudan Rume arrived as the second cup of a morning I'd already decided was going to be significant. Entry #37 at Keryi — the Urabeast G1 Mosto Fermentation — had just landed as a process first. I walked to Asylum with the archive still open on my phone.

This was a Yellow Sudan Rume mutation, Extended Fermentation Natural (EF2) — a processing method that takes what natural fermentation does to fruit development and extends it deliberately, coaxing geraniol and lemongrass esters to the surface. The hot phase was all red fruits: dominant, bright, acidic. Then the temperature shifted and lemongrass clarified. Then something quieter — dark cherry, almost like concentrated fruit candy, but never crossing into sweetness that felt artificial.

Two process firsts in one morning. The archive has never had a day like it, and I'm not sure it will again anytime soon. Some sessions you plan. Others you just show up for.

WHAT THE FIRST HALF TAUGHT ME

Process clarity is everything — and washed isn't boring.

I came in knowing I preferred washed coffees. What I didn't expect was how much the archive would confirm it, entry after entry. Washed process doesn't mean plain — it means the terroir, the varietal genetics, and the altitude are doing the talking. When I drink a washed Gesha at 2,100 MASL, every note I taste is the mountain. That's not boring. That's the whole point.

The conical brewer problem is real.

I logged two separate sessions this half where V60 conical geometry produced citric flatness with no thermal phase shift — the signature of fines accumulation at the drain. The same coffee on a flat-bottom brewer tells a completely different story. Flat burrs, flat bottom. That's my setup preference now, and the data backs it up.

Some of the best sessions weren't about the coffee.

The March afternoon at Narrative with Aanya — her first specialty filter, a Salvadoran Natural she described as tasting like apricot before I said anything — is logged in the archive. So is the April session at Asylum where she ordered a second cup without prompting. The coffee was good. The company made it matter.

The archive changes how you drink.

Once you start logging seriously, you can't stop. You notice things you used to let pass. The mid-cool phase shift. Whether the acidity holds as the temperature drops. What a barista's equipment choice tells you before the cup even arrives. It slows you down. I think that's the point.

WHAT I'M CHASING IN H2

- Eugenioides**
A diploid species — almost no caffeine, extreme sweetness. Near-mythical in availability.
- Homeground Experience Room**
Tasting lab format, EK43 + P64 on-site. National champion pedigree. Long overdue.
- Glyph Supply Co**
Jurong. Farm-specific tasting menu. A barista recommended it in May. I haven't made it there yet.
- Oaks Coffee Co**
Jervis Tan — 2025 National Barista Champion — is behind the bar. Enough said.
- Tokyo / Melbourne**
The first international expansion beyond Asia. Apartment Coffee Singapore is ranked No.6 globally. I want to see what that context looks like elsewhere.

H1 IN NUMBERS

SGD \$242.95	total documented spend across 23 sessions
SGD \$5.10	cheapest cup — a Kyuukei house blend
MYR 35	most expensive — Hacienda La Florida, Johor (~SGD 11 at current rate)
95%	of sessions on flat burr grinders
47%	washed process — dominant, as expected
1	non-Arabica species — the Liberica at Corner Corner
9	entries from Colombia — the archive's home country
0	times I ordered a milk-based drink for the audit

UNTIL THE CLOSING SHOT

The second issue will cover July to December. I don't know yet what it will contain — that's rather the point. If you have a café, a bean, or a producer you think belongs in the archive, I'm listening. The best recommendations have always come from people who care as much as I do. See you at the end of the year.